



DISEC

**DISARMAMENT
AND INTERNATIONAL
SECURITY COMMITTEE**

**Model United Nations
Conference - Global**

FROM THE COMMITTEE BUREAU

Honourable Delegates,

The Disarmament and International Security Committee bureau welcomes delegates to MUNCGLOBAL's flagship conference in Ghana, MUNC-GH.

This Background Guide examines how arms control, disarmament and post-conflict remediation intersect with environmental protection, and it provides the context needed to craft measures that advance both security and sustainability. As delegates to the Disarmament and International Security Committee, you face the critical challenge of addressing armaments in tandem with environmental stewardship.

The world's armaments – from nuclear arsenals to infantry rifles – have immense social and environmental costs. This bureau calls on delegates to propose arms control measures that promote peace and protect the planet. Consider how disarmament (e.g. fewer weapons, demilitarization) can free resources for sustainable development, and how military practices can be made greener. We encourage pragmatic strategies that integrate arms control with climate and environmental goals, such as transparency in military emissions and disposal of obsolete weapons. Please use the guide to prepare proposals on transparency, lifecycle management of weapons, and remediation of conflict-related pollution. The bureau is available for questions. We look forward to rigorous debate and pragmatic recommendations.

TOPIC BACKGROUND

Arms proliferation and armed conflict profoundly affect society, security and the environment. Globally, military expenditure is at a record high – \$2.7 trillion in 2024 yet these investments have not yielded greater peace. In fact, resources spent on weapons can crowd out spending on climate action, health and education. The UN Secretary-General’s recent report notes that the surge in military spending coincides with slowed progress on sustainable development and environmental deterioration. For example, building and maintaining weapons systems consumes fossil fuels.

Armed conflicts themselves wreak environmental havoc. Warfare can pollute air and water, destroy forests, and create toxic waste. Artillery shells and bullets contain heavy metals and chemicals; landmines and unexploded weapons can poison soil for decades. The destruction of infrastructure (bombed cities, burned oil fields) releases hazardous substances and greenhouse gases. One source notes that war-related shipwrecks have spilled over 15 million tonnes of oil into oceans. Chemical weapons dumped after World War II still contaminate seas. The Geneva Environment Network highlights that war often “pollutes water, torches crops, poisons soils,” leading to food insecurity and ruined livelihoods. Furthermore, resource extraction (like oil or timber) has fueled conflicts – at least 40% of intrastate wars in recent decades were tied to struggles over natural resources. Thus, arms and conflict can trap societies in a vicious cycle of violence and environmental damage.

Arms control and disarmament can benefit the environment. Fewer weapons mean less production pollution and more fiscal space for green projects. Eliminating landmines restores agricultural land.

Demilitarization in times of peace redirects manufacturing towards civilian needs. For instance, reductions in nuclear arsenals under treaties (e.g. New START) have not only eased tensions but also lowered the risk of environmental catastrophe from nuclear war. Even conventional disarmament helps: scrap metal from decommissioned tanks can be recycled for infrastructure. The UN Agenda for Disarmament (2018) explicitly links cutting weapons to sustainable development.

Delegates should consider existing frameworks: the Arms Trade Treaty (2013) regulates cross-border trade in conventional weapons, aiming to prevent arms fueling conflicts and human rights abuses. The Chemical Weapons Convention and Biological Weapons Convention outlaw the most polluting arms. Small arms and light weapons also receive attention (e.g. UN Programme of Action on SALW). Environmental impact is increasingly recognized: UN Sustainable Development Goal 16.4 calls for a significant reduction of illicit arms flows. The Secretary-General's report on military spending calls for "a race towards a sustainable future" instead of an arms race.

Possible committee actions include reinforcing transparency (requiring states to report on their arms holdings), expanding arms embargoes (to prevent conflict escalation), and promoting green military practices. For example, governments could be encouraged to calculate and reduce their military carbon footprints. Alternatively, delegates might propose an international fund financed by arms sale taxes to aid climate mitigation in war-torn regions. Expect debate between security priorities and environmental ones. Countries facing real security threats may resist cuts, while others may push for stronger arms control. The challenge is finding common ground: for example, confidence-building measures (joint exercises, inspections) can both enhance trust and open dialogue on environmental standards.

COMMITTEE BACKGROUND

The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC), also known as First Committee of the General Assembly, deals with global peace and security issues. Its mandate covers disarmament and control of both conventional and non-conventional weapons. DISEC addresses threats to international peace – from nuclear weapons to terrorism – and seeks solutions through treaties and norms.

At the UN level, discussions on arms often occur in DISEC (First Committee) and in disarmament bodies (like the Conference on Disarmament in Geneva). For this simulation, assume DISEC is holding a plenary on arms and the environment. Topics under DISEC usually include nuclear disarmament, non-proliferation, small arms, new military technologies, and now emerging: security and sustainability. Recent UN resolutions have begun to acknowledge environmental issues, for example by encouraging states to include military emissions in climate reporting or by discussing the environmental aspects of disarmament in UNGA resolutions. Note the linkage to SDGs: targets like 16.4 (illicit arms reduction) and 13.3 (climate education, which relates indirectly through awareness) apply. The UN Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) works on cross-cutting issues like disarmament's role in development. Delegates should be aware of these cross-cutting initiatives but focus on DISEC's purview: multilateral arms control.

Historically, DISEC resolutions often reaffirm treaties (e.g. encouraging ratification of the Arms Trade Treaty) or set up expert panels. A resolution on this topic might urge Member States to join arms control agreements, strengthen regulations, and support environmental remediation in conflict zones. Preparatory research might include each country's military expenditures, arms exports/imports, and any participation in disarmament treaties (NPT, CWC, ATT, etc.).

Also consider civil society input: NGOs like UNEP or OCHA sometimes release reports on war's environmental impact (these can be cited in debate as supportive evidence).

COMMITTEE STRUCTURE

DISEC includes all UN Member States. It typically operates through general debate followed by thematic clusters. For this session, the chairpersons will facilitate two main sub-groups: one on Controlling Arms and Weapons (e.g. non-proliferation, conventional arms limits) and another on Arms and the Environment (e.g. military emissions, conflict pollution). Delegates may form alliances based on interests; e.g. nuclear powers on one side, disarmament advocates on another. Resolutions in First Committee require majority vote but often pass by consensus on technical issues.

Each delegation should prepare country statements and draft resolutions. Possible resolutions could include calls for: integration of environmental assessments into arms programs; creation of UN trust funds for disarmament and climate projects; encouraging national inventories of military emissions; and strengthening the Arms Trade Treaty's environmental considerations. Guest speakers could include representatives of UNODA, UNEP, or ICRC (which works on conflict aftermath).

Debate rules follow standard GA procedure. Speakers list, moderated caucuses, amendments. Given the complexity, draft resolutions may undergo multiple redrafts. Delegates should cite authoritative sources to back their claims (e.g. UNODA data, reputable studies). Ultimately, the aim is to merge security and sustainability: for example, a resolution might pledge that cuts in military budgets should partly fund sustainable development, or that major arms exporters agree to bind export licenses to environmental and human rights criteria. By linking arms control to the 2030 Agenda (e.g. freeing resources for SDGs), delegates can frame disarmament as a path to global well-being.